

THROUGH THE AGES

Art

Female artists have existed since prehistory, although their achievements were frequently overlooked. Since the 19th century, women have embraced a succession of new art media and practices that do not have the weight of male tradition behind them.

PHOTOGRAPH BY JULIA MARGARET CAMERON OF ELLEN TERRY, 1863



WOMEN'S ART is rooted in a long history of traditional crafts, including pottery, quilting, beadwork, and weaving.

Work by female artists has often been dismissed as merely “craft” and denied the status of “fine art” in a male-dominated art world. Consequently, much of the female art throughout history went unrecorded.

African women's art has not been fully acknowledged, despite a rich tradition of creativity, such as the geometric paintings on the houses of Ndebele women in South Africa, a custom that dates from the 18th century.

Nonetheless, evidence of women's art dates back thousands of years. In the 4th century BCE, Helena of Egypt produced a painting of the Battle of Issus; French needlewomen worked on the Bayeux Tapestry; 12th-century German abbess Hildegard von Bingen painted striking illustrations for religious manuscripts in jewel-like colors; and in Yuan Dynasty China (1271–1368), Guan Daosheng painted paintings of bamboo plants that are considered masterpieces of Chinese art.

► Cubo-Futurism

Painterly Architectonic is one of a series of works that Lyubov Popova painted from 1916 to 1917. Part of the Russian vanguard that first experimented with geometrical abstraction, she mixed medieval Russian art with new avant-garde techniques.

“The **fact** that I am a **woman ... comes into play** in [how] I structure a **canvas**.”

JUDY CHICAGO, ARTIST, 1999

In Renaissance Europe, art production was usually based in family workshops in which women worked alongside fathers and brothers. Although some of these—such as the portrait painter Sofonisba Anguissola and Marietta Robusti, the daughter of Venetian master painter Tintoretto—were renowned painters in their time, none took over the family firms.

